



Alagu Balaraman
Head, IT,
Godfrey Phillips India Ltd

We use video conferencing for two reasons: To increase the frequency of contact between remote teams and to reduce the cost of travel. We changed the layout of the conference room for this purpose and saw to it that lighting was appropriate. We had to install a power supply to shoulder the additional power needs and got an IP-based Wide Area Network in place. As part of basic infrastructure, we got an ISDN line, too. A Polycom camera was the preferred device for image and audio capture. As a result, it has helped cut national and international travel costs. Apart from allowing meetings to be held in a short timespan, it also allows face-to-face interaction with our colleagues as well as business partners. We did a cost-to-benefit analysis before implementing it and found that the savings on travel alone have been enough to offset the equipment costs, and more.



BUSINESS,

VIDEO CONFERENCING AS part of your business is no longer a futuristic concept—it is here, and it is now. Video conferencing not only helps bridge distances, it also helps bring down travel costs, cuts down on unutilised man hours, and brings a company face to face with domain experts at a nominal cost. Here's what five senior industry personalities have to say about video conferencing



Illustration Atul Deshmukh



Mohan U Deshpande
Professor-in-Charge, DEP,
IIT Bombay

IIT uses group-based videoconferencing to extend its classrooms to include geographically distant students wishing to pursue high-quality advanced engineering education. We use a full-fledged satellite uplink facility to capture audio and video inputs from live IIT classrooms with full digital imaging support to faculty. HCL Comnet manages the VSAT (Very Small Aperture Terminal) network. The infrastructure was built with donations from reputed alumni like Infosys CEO Nandan Nilekani and venture capitalist Kanwal Rekhi; grants from the Ministry of Communications and IT, and international agencies. IP-multicasting allows two-way audio and video interaction. This lets a student attending the lecture at a remote centre ask questions and get real-time replies. This facility is now the only one of its kind in educational videoconferencing in India, thus ensuring that IIT faculty can now reach a remote student, and also give him the feel of classroom participation. We were driven by the vision of bringing IIT education to students who are as capable, but have limited resources.